

completely to use the weapon's alt-fire. It's incredible how the halfway resistance is just tight enough for you to not pull it completely by accident in a heated battle.

If you have played Control, you will feel right at home with the action in Returnal. It is fast-paced with you dashing to avoid getting hit,

MOAR!

TESTED ON:

PS5

DEVELOPER:

Housemarque

PUBLISHER:

Sony Interactive Entertainment

PLATFORMS:

PS5

PRICE:

₹4,999

every time you pick up an item, increase the cooldown time of your alt-fire, reduce the melee damage effect and more. There are ways for you to remove a Parasite as well. Some of them will detach after their function is over while others will require you to kill a certain number of enemies or craft an item or open a locked gate, so on and so forth.

You also have Obolites that you collect when you kill enemies or find them lying around in the game. You can consider

runs of mine were too easy as the loot I picked up gave me some truly invincible abilities. At other times I felt quite underpowered.

GRAPHICS AND SOUND

Returnal runs in a dynamic 4K at 60FPS. The game looks stunning with its dark and dingy forest to the vastly open red desert and other environments I would rather not spoil here.

The load times in the game deserve special attention too. When you die, the game plays out the opening crash animation but you can skip it. This



using your melee weapon to attack at close range and more. You will acquire different abilities that you can use. Some are the standard health regeneration, while others let you disable turrets and some let you shoot projectiles from your suit every time you get shot. Even though there are a number of guns in the game you can only carry one at a time. You have the standard pistol, assault rifle, shotgun and even one gun that shoots venom. Each weapon has its own alt-fire and these are not standard. So, each time you get a shotgun, for example, the alt-fire could be different. The alt-fire includes homing shots, sniper shots, blasts of energy, grenades and more.

In addition to the weapons, there are Parasites that can be found throughout the game. These have both a positive and/or a negative effect. Some of them offer very useful abilities like regenerating health, the ability to use a key twice to open a door, reduce the cooldown time of your alt-fire and more. On the other hand, they could have negative effects as well like reducing your health

them to be the game's currency. Collecting Obolites lets you craft items like a health pack or interact with machines that increase your maximum health.

The enemies are quite varied. You have the standard alien creatures that throw projectiles at you and get close for a melee attack. You have turrets. You also have flying enemies and enemies shaped like trees that shoot gunk on the ground that slows your movement. There are some larger flying enemies, a crab-like enemy with an indestructible shell and some larger enemies that remind me of the Marauder from Doom Eternal.

Returnal's rogue-lite structure ensures you don't face the same set of areas back-to-back in each run. These levels are procedurally generated until you need to hit a specific story beat in which case, you visit very specific areas.

Overall, the gameplay in Returnal is frantic, fun and most definitely enjoyable. However, I think the developers need to put in a little bit of effort to balance the loot on each run. Some

means you can start the game after a death in a matter of seconds. Even when you fast travel, it takes no more than a few seconds.

Moving over to the sound, each gun in the game has its own unique thud and the screeching of the alien life forms can give you a chill. While the game shows off the 3D audio potential of the PS5 I found the surround sound experience to be good. While the background score in the game is sombre, it's the heat of the action and Selene's own audio logs that dominate the soundtrack and it suits the theme of the game perfectly.

VERDICT

Returnal's rogue-lite formula mixed with an interesting Sci-fi story, and fast-paced combat will ensure you enjoy every time you live die repeat. For the rest of you, who feel an asking price of ₹5,000 is high for the game, can wait for a price drop before dipping your toes into a game that is extremely challenging but rewarding for those that endure. *